

Biden book stirs fresh trauma for Democrats

A ‘blame game’ follows new claims that aides hid the president’s decline

BY NAFTALI BENDAVID, DAN MERICA AND PAUL KANE

A growing number of Democrats are publicly second-guessing their party’s handling of the last election, acknowledging that President Joe Biden’s delayed withdrawal was damaging and in some cases conceding they were too quick to dismiss questions about his age and mental acuity.

The criticism, and self-criticism, comes as a new book — “Original Sin: President Biden’s Decline, Its Cover-Up, and His Disastrous Choice to Run Again” by Jake Tapper and Alex Thompson — blames Democrats’ defeat in large part on Biden’s aides who, it asserts, hid the extent of his decline.

The former president and his supporters forcefully reject that notion. But the renewed questions, along with Biden’s public comments responding to those claims, are sending shivers through a Democratic Party still traumatized by November’s loss to Donald Trump.

Rep. Ro Khanna (D-California), an outspoken supporter of Biden before he ended his reelection campaign last summer, acknowledged in a statement to The Washington Post on Wednesday that he had been mistaken in backing the former president’s reelection.

“In my few interactions at public events, I found him coherent and proud of his record, but it is now painfully obvious he should not have run,” Khanna said. “We should have had an open primary. We must acknowledge this truth to regain trust with the American people.”

Kentucky Gov. Andy Beshear — a potential Democratic presidential candidate in 2028 — said in an interview Wednesday that it would have helped the party if Biden had ended his reelection bid earlier than July. “In retrospect, if the president was going to drop out, dropping out earlier would have give any candidate a little more time,” Beshear said.

SEE BIDEN ON A22

Buttigieg: Teasing presidential run, he lays out vision for Democrats. **A8**

Review: The book pins Trump’s win squarely on Biden’s decline. **C1**

Tariffs eased on news of pain to Trump’s base

BY JEFF STEIN, NATALIE ALLISON AND DAVID J. LYNCH

Some of the president’s top aides saw an opening.

Throughout April, President Donald Trump’s sky-high tariffs on imports from China had rippled through the U.S. and global economies. But the president was reluctant to move too quickly to lower the penalties on Beijing, believing that the United States needed to stomach some short-

ADVISERS SAW CHANCE TO SWAY PRESIDENT

Result was weekend talks, partial deal with China

term economic pain to achieve a major rebalancing in trade and that China had more to lose in the standoff.

By the end of the month, though, a growing number of blue-collar workers whom Trump saw as part of his political base — including longshoremen and

truckers — began warning that tariffs and a near-total cessation of trade with China were hurting them. Behind the scenes, White House Chief of Staff Susie Wiles, Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent and other aides told Trump that his own voters were in danger if the tariffs did not come down,

according to two people familiar with the matter who spoke on the condition of anonymity to describe private discussions. That gave them a path to initiating negotiations with the Chinese, which culminated this past weekend in Geneva with a partial deal to reduce tariffs between the world’s two biggest economies. One White House official cautioned, however, that multiple factors contributed to the trade talks in Switzerland.

“The key argument was that

this was beginning to hurt Trump’s supporters — Trump’s people,” one person briefed on the talks said. “It gave Susie a key window.”

Trump’s pullback reflected the core tension that has bedeviled the White House as he has tried using tariffs to remake the global economy in record time: What he seeks is virtually impossible

SEE TARIFFS ON A16

Trade tension: British spurn some American beef and chicken. **A16**



BANDAR ALJALUD/SAUDI ROYAL PALACE/AP

President Donald Trump greets Ahmed al-Sharaa, the interim president of Syria and former al-Qaeda-linked rebel, at the Saudi royal palace in Riyadh. The two met for more than half an hour Wednesday, a day after Trump said he would ease sanctions on the country.

Some rioters now aim to turn a profit from Jan. 6

BY ELLIE SILVERMAN AND DREW HARWELL

A man convicted of beating police officers during the Jan. 6, 2021, U.S. Capitol attack now sells \$50 “J6 Hostages” T-shirts and is launching a 22-stop nationwide “Freedom Tour.”

Another, who calls himself a “J6 Former Felon” on X, is soliciting donations for a personal “Freedom Fund” to support a cross-country RV tour with his wife. They want to spread their message about what he describes as “corrupted” legal, law enforce-

ment and prison systems.

Dozens pardoned in attack on Capitol have turned online influencers

Absolved by President Donald Trump’s sweeping pardons and feeling vindicated by his reelection, rioters who once lay low in the aftermath of the attack on the Capitol or otherwise felt unwelcome on mainstream platforms are taking on new identities as online influencers.

The Washington Post identified more than four dozen who now promote themselves online as “J6ers” and have worked to profit from their connection to the day’s chaos, recording podcasts, announcing runs for public office and advertising mer-

chandise lines.

Many are finding a place on X, which under billionaire Trump adviser Elon Musk has cut back on moderating election disinformation and become the MAGA movement’s main online home. Several said in interviews they felt free to openly identify as Jan. 6 “hostages” and “political prisoners” without fear of penalty.

“The culture has changed,” said former Proud Boys chairman Henry “Enrique” Tarrio, who was convicted of seditious

SEE INFLUENCERS ON A18

A century later, family’s birthright citizenship fight goes on

Norman Wong’s ancestor won a landmark Supreme Court ruling. A new case threatens his legacy.

BY DAVID NAKAMURA

SAN FRANCISCO — One hundred and twenty seven years after Wong Kim Ark’s landmark Supreme Court victory enshrined birthright citizenship, Norman Wong arrived at the University of California at Berkeley in late April on a quest to protect his great-grandfather’s legacy.

Wong, 75, clutched a piece of paper before a campus forum on immigration — a short speech he had revised four times — but he carried no photos or family heirlooms. For most of his life, he had not heard of Wong Kim Ark, a poor cook born to Chinese immigrants in San Francisco in 1870.

But since President Donald Trump signed an executive order



BRIAN L. FRANK/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Norman Wong stands before a mural in San Francisco’s Chinatown featuring Wong Kim Ark, bottom left, his great-grandfather.

in January to end automatic citizenship for U.S.-born children of undocumented immigrants and foreign visitors, Norman Wong has been thrust into a life of unexpected local celebrity and political activism. He is held up by supporters as a living testament to the man whose fight for American citizenship — with its presumed guarantees of civil rights, free speech and due process — had gotten lost through the years.

“It was a piece of history, but it was not relevant history, to be truthful, at the time,” Wong said in an interview, referring to the

SEE LEGACY ON A6

Birthright ban: Justices will weigh injunctions halting Trump order. **A7**

A scramble for forecasters ahead of hurricane season

BY SCOTT DANCE

Some National Weather Service forecasting teams are so critically understaffed that the agency is offering to pay moving expenses for any staff willing to transfer to those offices, according to notices recently sent to employees and obtained by The Washington Post. The worker shortages have forced several offices to stop operating 24 hours a day — a drastic step for an agency whose ethos is to prepare and warn a “weather-ready” nation.

The 155 vacancies the agency is seeking to fill by May 27 include key weather forecasting positions at offices in coastal Texas and Louisiana, states that could

face threats when the Atlantic hurricane season begins in a few weeks. The National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration, the weather service’s parent agency, is also asking large numbers of meteorologists to move to offices in Alaska and across the northern Plains in Nebraska, Wyoming and South Dakota.

In four forecasting offices — two in California’s Central Valley, one in western Kansas and another in eastern Kentucky — the staffing is so thin that there aren’t enough meteorologists to cover an overnight shift, according to the National Weather Service Employees Organization, a union representing NOAA rank and file. Offices in Wyoming,

SEE NOAA ON A22

IN THE NEWS

Drinking water The EPA said it plans to roll back limits on “forever chemicals” that were set under a Biden White House standard. **A11**

Georgetown researcher Badar Khan Suri was freed from ICE custody and was set to return to Virginia after a judge found that the Trump administration probably violated his rights. **B1**

THE NATION Trump’s cuts to public health could reverse 2024’s plunge in drug deaths, experts warn. **A3**
A Pentagon-National Airport hotline has been disconnected for years, an official testified. **A9**

THE WORLD In Syria, Israel pursues an opening with the persecuted Druze religious minority. **A12**
Planned talks between Russia and Ukraine have upended a European push for sanctions. **A13**

THE ECONOMY Boeing is years behind and has lost billions of dollars on its government contract to build a new Air Force One. **A15**
Fired federal workers who screened coal miners for black lung were back on the job a day after a judge ordered their reinstatement. **A17**

THE REGION Maryland’s long-held triple-A bond rating was downgraded, and the state’s leaders were quick to lay the blame on Trump. **B1**
Authorities said they probably found the body of a boy who was swept away by floodwaters in central Virginia. **B1**

SPORTS The Commanders schedule is out and includes at least five primetime games, plus Dallas on Christmas Day. **D1**

LOCAL LIVING Bit by bit, an Atlanta couple are returning their mid-century modern home to its original decor and design.

BUSINESS NEWS.....A15
COMICS.....C5
OBITUARIES.....B4
OPINION PAGES.....A19
TELEVISION.....C4
WORLD NEWS.....A12

CONTENT © 2025
The Washington Post
Year 148, No. 54217

0 170628 21100 3